

ally, matches happened through someone known to both persons—a family member, friend or colleague. But there was someone who would vouch for the character and personality [of the prospective partner]," says Dr Manoj Sharma, social media expert and psychiatrist at the National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro-Sciences (NIMHANS), Bengaluru. "On digital platforms, you are starting from scratch, and it is crucial that people take time to get to know each other. Text messages alone fail to show the user's body language; so, a video call should follow. Offline meetings should happen in public and with backup support."

Experts say the first signs of abusive behaviour can be detected in online interactions and the way a user communicates. "Offline abuse, or indeed murder, doesn't just happen overnight but usually after long periods of domestic violence," says feminist activist Kavita Krishnan. "We must support victims of abuse from day one, give them the confidence to speak out and take action to stop abuse. It's only if you offer non-judgemental help that the victim will call you every single time she's in danger, which may save her life."

9 SIMPLE RULES FOR SAFE DATING

1. Spot and call out any toxic dating behaviour
2. Set clear expectations and boundaries
3. Do not share videos or photos you might later regret
4. Avoid sharing your banking details and passwords
5. Do not rush into a hook-up; try to know the person first
6. Chat on video before meeting in person
7. Meet in public spaces the first few times
8. Keep friends/ family in the loop, even after your relationship goes offline
9. Be aware of your dating app's safety features

Unhealthy dating trends

In June, a 28-year-old woman was allegedly raped in a Delhi hotel by someone she met on a dating app. A month earlier, the Faridabad police busted an extortion racket when it arrested a trio that had allegedly targeted some 25 men on Grindr—a social networking app for the LGBTQ community—after filming objectionable videos. In addition to growing safety concerns about meeting strangers online, there are other psychological worries, too. Many dating app users have reported being victims of unhealthy dating trends—from bullying to stalking, and breadcrumbing (a series of fake promises and expectations) to ghosting (someone suddenly vanishing from your digital life). In 2021, a Bumble survey found that 83 per cent women using the app in India experienced online harassment, one in three on a weekly basis. This made over half the women surveyed feel unsafe, and 48 per cent feel angry. The same year, a global survey commissioned by cybersecurity provider Kaspersky noted that while the safety features of nine popular dating apps (that also operate in India) had improved, the threat of cyberstalking and doxing (publishing private information online) remained.

A key contributing factor to such behaviour is the lack of consequences. As Kuljeet Rawal, a senior advocate, says, "Over time, one has seen the many demerits of online dating and the long-term impact on privacy, the reason being there is no specific legislation, ensuring and regulating online dating apps and their proper use." Indeed, the Information Technology Act has no standalone section that defines cyberstalking as a crime. To file a case, the complainant needs to furnish